



SHAKING IT UP Stills from the Shakun Batra-directed *Gehraiyaan* (left); and *Kapoor & Sons*

In *Ek Main Aur Ekk Tu* (2012), arguably one of the more underseen debuts of the previous decade, writer-director Shakun Batra redefined the rules of romance. He told a love story that didn't have the kind of 'happily ever after' we have been trained to expect or recognise in Hindi cinema. Four years later, Batra followed it up with *Kapoor & Sons* (2016), a sensational family thriller that underlined with piercing clarity that it's not always about loving your family—sometimes, what's harder is living with them. Now with *Gehraiyaan* (streaming on Amazon Prime Video from February 11), a love triangle starring Deepika Padukone, Siddhant Chaturvedi, Ananya Panday and newcomer Dhairya Karwa, Batra wants to change the way Hindi movies villainise infidelity.

Growing up, Batra remembers questioning infidelity and the morality behind it. Reading *Intimacy*, British novelist Hanif Kureishi's 1998 novel, provided the 39-year-old filmmaker with the necessary inspiration. "I forget the exact quote from the book but it basically said that sometimes you have an affair not to find the one but to find yourself. I began from that when I was writing this film," Batra says over a Zoom call. "I was more interested in figuring out the stuff that is beneath the surface. Not so much what was actually happening but what was not being said."

IN HIS FILMS, SHAKUN BATRA REDEFINES THE RULES OF ROMANCE. HE FEELS HINDI CINEMA OVER-SIMPLIFIES RELATIONSHIPS

Much of it stemmed from Batra realising that Hindi cinema is prone to oversimplifying relationships. "For a while, I've wanted to explore a more complex, grown-up relationship. But I also knew it would be boring to make yet another relationship drama where people look at each other with googly eyes until their libidos implode."

Indeed, Hindi cinema's long-standing hesitancy toward physical intimacy is frustrating. Batra remembers being influenced by the film industry's asexual gaze while making *Ek Main Aur Ekk Tu*. "At the time, I felt too shy as a storyteller. I felt confined by how we had told stories before and I didn't want to shake the boat." This time around, Batra wasn't making a film about a platonic relationship. So, he was keener to explore a romantic coupling where physicality played a huge part—a relationship drama that wasn't constrained by moral and social mores.

It also helped that Batra, by his own admission, is averse to neatly resolving conflicts with happy endings. Instead, he likes to tell stories that are "open to interpretation and conversation". His filmography is proof. Both his previous films have turned the idea of a conventional film ending on its head and have, instead, resembled the start of a new beginning. "I don't think that a happy ending makes [for] a satisfying ending," admits the filmmak-